

THE ESCALATING TREND OF **ONLINE SHOPPING** CONTINUES

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The emerging retail industry in India has also given space for online shopping to gain traction among consumers in numerous ways since the early 2000s. A retailers' association has stated that online shopping has proven to be beneficial for them as it gained popularity rapidly. Retailers enjoy the online shopping market because of superior customer service, global reach, mass customisation, specialised stores and no costs in real estate. It is not only convenient and fast but also turns out to be many times cheaper for consumers.

Online shopping has enhanced so much that customers can buy anything online, from fashion items to medicines. This trend is not only augmenting in India but across the world, and the market is likely to touch US\$ 230 billion by the end of 2028.

Rise of e-commerce in India

UK-based global computer scientist Tim Berners-Lee started the world's first Web server and browser in the UK. A couple of years later in 1994, the world's first online



banking and online pizza delivery by Pizza Hut was started. To secure online shopping and its data, Netscape, in the same year, introduced SSL encryption to strengthen the security of online platforms.

In the early 1990s, Internet penetration in India was quite low and so was its user base as compared to the US and some European nations. Even though online shopping commenced in many parts of the world, in India its journey was slow and disorderly. Due to slow Internet penetration, people were not aware of its benefits and usage. Most

importantly, the question of quality assurance was trending those days. People were not eager to buy items without seeing and/or touching them.

In 1995, online shopping began in India, but when the Internet was booming in the late 2000s, it gained popularity with the induction of renowned auction website www.bazee.com. To add to the already-tough competition, American billionaire-cum-business magnate, Jeff Bezos started the world's first online bookstore, www.amazon.com,